

GOLDEN MEMORIES

Meet four Olympic champions who **redefined greatness** and left an indelible mark on sports history. These athletes not only clinched gold but also inspired millions with their incredible feats.

Team Sportstar



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PAAVO NURMI

Finland's mastery of 1,500m, the 5,000m, the 10,000m, the cross-country races (which were then part of the competition schedule) and the 3,000m steeplechase, which continued until Moscow 1980, was cemented by the great Paavo Nurmi. After the 1916 Olympics was cancelled due to World War 1, Nurmi was successful in winning the 10,000m and the individual and team cross-country gold medals after a silver in the 5,000m at Antwerp in 1920. At Paris 1924, Nurmi won five gold medals in six days, with those in the 1,500m and 5,000m coming within an hour of each other. He subsequently won the cross-country (both individual and team) and 3,000m team races, but the Finnish authorities would not allow him to take part in any further events, though Nurmi did make several pleas that he be allowed to run the 10,000m. An angered Nurmi ran the distance on another track outside the Olympic venue, clocking a much better time than the official winner. At Amsterdam 1928, Nurmi took the 10,000m gold while finishing second in the 5,000m and the 3,000m. Nurmi wanted to win a 10th Olympic gold medal and continued training to take part in the marathon in Los Angeles in 1932. However, just before the Games, he was banned by the International Amateur Athletics Federation based on a complaint filed by the Swedish federation, citing that he was no longer an amateur. However, Nurmi was given the honour of lighting the Games Flame in Helsinki in 1952.